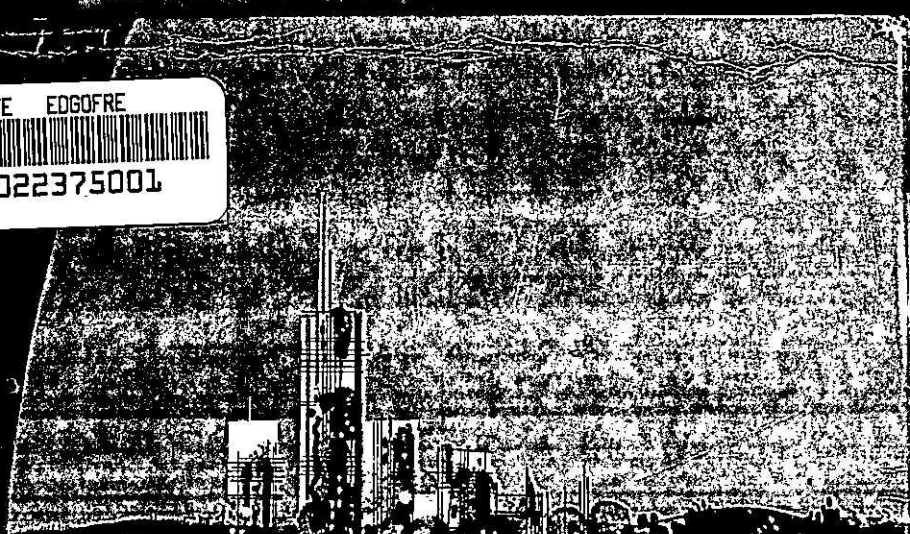


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THE EDGE OF REALITY

A progress report on
Unidentified flying Objects

**J. Allen Hynek and
Jacques Vallee**

theatrics, as in the Boianai sightings. Or a light seems to be examining something, moving around an object as though it were examining it—also the trajectories are not random, discs will hover and then take off rapidly. Upon discovery, in the cases of humanoids, the tendency is just the opposite to contact. The reaction seems to be to run away. These cases do not bespeak a natural phenomenon.

3

The Scientists at Work

*Unknown Objects in Space and in the Air,
and What Science Is Doing about Them*

"I believe UFOs belong to someone else and they are from some other civilization."—Astronaut Gene Cernan, January 4, 1973, at a Los Angeles press conference.

"I believe UFOs, under intelligent control, have visited our planet for thousands of years."—Astronaut Gordon Cooper, July 1, 1973, at Cape Canaveral, Florida.

"Odds are that UFOs exist."—Astronaut John Young, November 28, 1973, at a Seattle, Washington, speaking engagement.

—As reported in the press.

TABLE OF UFO SIGHTINGS BY ASTRONAUTS

(From a list compiled by Mr. G. Fawcett.)

February 20, 1962 — John Glenn, piloting his Mercury capsule, saw three objects follow him and then overtake him at varying speeds.

May 24, 1962 — Mercury VII: Scott Carpenter reported photographing firefly-like objects with a hand camera and that he had what looked like a good shot of a saucer.

May 30, 1962 — X15 Pilot Joe Walton photographed five disc-like objects.

July 17, 1962 — X15 Pilot Robert White photographed objects about thirty feet away from his craft while about fifty-eight miles up.

May 16, 1963 — Mercury IX: Gordon Cooper reported a greenish UFO with a red tail during his fifteenth orbit. He also reported other mysterious sightings over South America and Australia. The object he sighted over Perth, Australia, was caught on screens by ground tracking stations.

October 3, 1963 — Mercury VIII: Walter Schirra reported large glowing masses over the Indian Ocean.

March 8, 1964 — Voskhod 2: Russian cosmonauts reported an unidentified object just as they entered the earth's atmosphere.

June 3, 1964 — Gemini IV: Jim McDivitt reported he photographed several strange objects, including a cylindrical object with arms sticking out and an egg-shaped UFO with some sort of exhaust.

October 12, 1964 — Voskhod 1: Three Russian cosmonauts reported they were surrounded by a formation of swiftly moving disc-shaped objects.

December 4, 1965 — Gemini VIII: Frank Borman and Jim Lovell photographed twin oval-shaped UFOs with glowing undersides.

July 18, 1966 — Gemini X: John Young and Mike Collins saw a large, cylindrical object accompanied by two smaller, bright objects, which Young photographed. NASA failed to pick them up on screens.

September 12, 1966 — Gemini XI: Richard Gordon and Charles Conrad reported a yellow-orange UFO about six miles from them. It dropped down in front of them and then disappeared when they tried to photograph it.

November 11, 1966 — Gemini XII: Jim Lovell and Edwin Aldrin saw four UFOs linked in a row. Both spacemen said the objects were not stars.

December 21, 1968 — Apollo VIII: Frank Borman and Jim Lovell reported a "bogie" — an unidentified object — ten miles up.

July 16, 1969 — Apollo XI: This was the mission on which a UFO reportedly chased the spacecraft.

November 14, 1969 — Apollo XII: Astronauts Pete Conrad, Alan Bean and Dick Gordon said a UFO accompanied them to within 132,000 miles of the moon, preceding them all the way.

A JEALOUS PHENOMENON

The above series of observations by astronauts was the point of departure of our third session.

HASTINGS: What about various Apollo missions and the UFOs the astronauts saw? During Apollo 11, Neil Armstrong, Edwin Aldrin, and Michael Collins said they observed a UFO.

HYNEK: The astronauts? Some of the NASA movie frames that I examined were most interesting—particularly those taken on the Apollo 11 flight; one of the few for which NASA has not come up with some sort of explanation. And several astronauts have stated that they definitely saw things in space which they could not identify. Thus—it satisfies the definition of UFO! Unidentified!

Dr. Franklin E. Roach,² whose work covered only the earlier sightings by astronauts—B.C.—Before Condon,³ mentions those visual sightings made by astronauts in orbit that in his judgment remained unexplained. In fact, I've always admired how Franklin got himself off the hook by closing his chapter in the Condon Report by saying that those unidentified astronaut sightings remain "a challenge to the analyst." Very neat. He didn't attempt an answer, and as for suggesting that they might really be UFOs—well, that apparently was a no-no.

¹ See, for example, NASA photo #56663402, a single frame from a movie sequence (R. Emenegger, *UFOs, Past, Present, and Future*, Ballantine). It shows an object with some sort of structure in outline.

² An American astronomer, member of the Condon Committee, who wrote Chapter 6 of the Report, "Visual Observations Made by Astronauts."

³ Dr. Edward U. Condon, Project Director of the work, which was reported in "Scientific Study of Unidentified Flying Objects," 1968, Bantam edition.

HASTINGS: Did they say they saw something ahead of them?
 HYNNEK: Yes. Apparently Neil Armstrong was asleep at the time; I was told that the other two saw something that looked like an open book in the great distance, but when they looked at it through binoculars (they didn't photograph it, in that particular case), it was a cylindrical object.

Another related topic is the fact that people say, "Well, if these things are real, why don't our infrared satellites, why don't our radar networks, why don't our sky surveys, why don't the weather satellites and all that pick these things up?" Well, of course, we don't know whether they do or not. I certainly know that in the satellite tracking mission¹ we got a number of things that appeared on the films that were never tracked down; they weren't part of the mission! A person who says that the Baker-Nunn cameras never picked up anything is just dead wrong because I know they did. I was in charge of the project! We just didn't bother about it. It would have been too much work to investigate some strange lights; it would have diverted men from the job they were supposed to do; this undoubtedly is true in the case of radar. Radars do pick up all sorts of cockeyed things, but the military figures they're not of interest to a particular mission, so heck with it!

I have a wealthy friend in Texas whom I thought I might interest in this research, but his objection was that if the UFOs were real, more people would see them at any one time. He asked me, "Why is it such a localized thing? Why do two or three people here see it and lots of people around the town in a populated area don't see it?" Well, how do we know they don't? Lots of people don't report! I've had a number of cases where people have said that they didn't say anything about it because they fully expected to see it all written up in the papers the next day, and then were surprised to find that there was nothing in the paper about it! But, on the other hand, the UFO is what has been termed a "jealous phenomenon." A Boeing 747 is not a jealous

¹ Dr. Hynek was Associate Director of the Smithsonian Astrophysical Observatory from 1956 to 1960 and headed the United States satellite optical tracking program.

phenomenon, an eclipse isn't jealous, anyone can observe it. But a UFO is a "jealous phenomenon" in that it seems to show itself preferentially in a particular area; a UFO seems to be localized in both space and time.

WHY AREN'T THERE SOME PIECES?

HASTINGS: One question that comes up is, if they're around, why aren't they leaving some physical residues? Why haven't they dropped a few nuts and bolts?

HYNNEK: Ah, that comes up time and again! Why isn't there any hardware left behind? Surely they must crash sometimes, surely they must. . . . Well, I think we should bring these things up. Sure, these are the obvious objections. We don't know the answer to that. Yet, there are a few cases where actual physical remains have been reported—but very few, and these have never been followed through to final proof. Not only would this require very ample funds but, well, what would constitute "final proof"? On the other hand, if you were a bushman in Australia, how many parts from a Boeing 747 would you be picking up? The bushman might see an airplane fly over his territory for many many years and not once be "fortunate" enough to be witness to an air crash. Think of the thousands of commercial planes flying daily over the U.S., yet years go by without a single crash.

HASTINGS: That is one of the baffling things, because we do know that they cause physical effects: the circles on the ground, broken branches, and so on. Why, if they cause physical effects, don't they leave physical remains at some time or another?

VALLEE: Accidents have been reported involving UFOs, and material has been picked up and has been analyzed and apparently, was unusual.

HYNNEK: Yes, but always someplace like Ubatuba, Brazil. Why not at least Oshkosh? Or Bangor, Maine?

HASTINGS: Are any of those fairly reliable?

HYNNEK: APRO¹ thinks that the magnesium sample from Ubatuba

¹ The Aerial Phenomena Research Organization, a private group with headquarters in Tucson, Arizona.